

Reality Drift: Master Index

Canonical Framework, Research, Essays, and Archives

A. Jacobs

Reality Drift is a framework developed by A. Jacobs between 2023 and 2026, with its primary formalization occurring during 2025–2026.

Reality Drift describes a condition in which a system remains functional and internally coherent while its representations, decisions, or outputs become progressively less aligned with the real-world conditions they are meant to track, explain, or affect.

The framework examines how that distance develops through representation, filtering, compression, proxy substitution, optimization, weakened feedback, and the loss of effective constraint. It also examines the consequences of that process across meaning, institutions, cognition, identity, and time.

Key concepts developed across the framework include Reality Drift, Semantic Fidelity, Recursive Compression, Constraint Collapse, Cognitive Drift, the Optimization Trap, Filter Fatigue, Synthetic Realness, the Drifted Self, and Temporal Drift. The project developed across several connected bodies of work, including the Reality Drift Framework, the Semantic Fidelity Project, and the Cognitive Drift Papers.

Coherence is not contact. The absence of failure is not proof of alignment.

Start Here

[Reality Drift Archive - Website](#)

Primary public web archive for the Reality Drift framework. The site brings together the central definitions, canonical concept papers, visual frameworks, research collections, interpretive essays, diagnostic guides, and applied examples developed across the project.

Key entry points:

- [Reality Drift Framework](#)
- [What Is Reality Drift?](#)
- [Reality Drift Framework Glossary](#)
- [Canonical Concept Papers](#)
- [Reality Drift Visual Diagrams](#)
- [Canonical Essay Map](#)
- [Reality Drift Ontology](#)
- [Cognitive Drift Glossary](#)
- [Semantic Fidelity Lexicon](#)

- [Archive Notice](#)

Primary Academic Paper

Reality Drift: How Symbolic Systems Lose the Ability to Correct Themselves

[SSRN](#) · [PhilArchive](#)

This is the principal academic treatment of the Reality Drift framework. The paper develops Reality Drift as a failure of self-correction in symbolic systems. It examines how representations, metrics, models, procedures, and other symbolic structures can remain internally coherent while becoming progressively less responsive to the realities they were created to describe, regulate, or improve.

Reality Drift Research Collection

The formal research corpus is organized primarily through Figshare.

[A. Jacobs - Figshare](#)

Primary author archive containing Reality Drift research papers, canonical concept papers, framework documents, and related formal materials.

- [Reality Drift Canonical Concept Papers](#) — Core concept papers and formal definitions for the framework.
- [Reality Drift: Canonical Definition, Mechanisms, and System Architecture](#) — Structural reference for the framework's definition, mechanisms, architecture, and conceptual relationships.
- [The Representation Stack](#) — Model of how reality becomes measurable, optimized, represented, and interpreted.
- [The Absence of Failure](#) — Five-paper series connecting Reality Drift to metrics, optimization, incentives, and institutional drift.
- [Reality Drift Framework Glossary](#) — Canonical vocabulary and definitions for the framework.
- [Reality Drift Canonical Overview & FAQ](#) — Compact orientation to the framework, its scope, and its development from 2023–2026.

Semantic Fidelity Research Collection

[Semantic Fidelity Project - Figshare](#)

The Semantic Fidelity Project studies how meaning survives, weakens, or mutates as language moves through compression, retrieval, summarization, generation, and artificial intelligence systems. Its central concern is whether meaning, intent, context, hierarchy, nuance, and interpretive structure survive transformation. The collection includes work on Semantic Fidelity, Semantic Drift, Fidelity Decay, Recursive Compression, Constraint Collapse, Ground Erosion, meaning degradation, AI evaluation, and representational failure.

- [Semantic Fidelity Project Paper Series \(SFP 01–06\)](#) — Core papers on Semantic Fidelity, meaning preservation, compression, and AI evaluation.
- [Semantic Fidelity Project Lexicon](#) — Working vocabulary for the project’s main concepts and failure modes.
- [Reality Drift Tools](#) — Practical evaluation, diagnostic, and governance tools for identifying and correcting drift.

Cognitive Drift Research Collection

[Cognitive Drift Papers - Figshare](#)

The Cognitive Drift Papers examine how cognition changes under conditions of acceleration, compression, AI feedback, symbolic overload, recursive mediation, and weakened constraint. The collection includes work on Cognitive Drift, Recursive Compression, Co-Cognition, Cognitive Compression Styles, human-AI feedback loops, meaning instability, closure and unresolved cognition, and externalized cognitive systems.

- [Cognitive Drift and Co-Cognition: Overview & FAQ](#) — Overview of Cognitive Drift, Co-Cognition, recursive feedback, AI-mediated thought, and semantic stability.
- [Co-Cognition: Overview & FAQ](#) — Focused reference for Co-Cognition and the structure of distributed human-AI thought.

Collected Reality Drift Essays

[Reality Drift Archive - Substack](#)

The main public essay archive for the Reality Drift framework. It develops the framework across systems, institutions, optimization, media, culture, meaning, artificial intelligence, and everyday forms of drift.

Selected essays:

- [Reality Drift: Why Modern Life Feels Off](#)
- [When Intelligence Scales, Reality Drifts](#)
- [Survivable Wrongness: Why Nothing Feels Right Anymore, Even When Everything Works](#)
- [The Optimization Trap: When Improvement Changes the Purpose](#)
- [Why Modern Systems No Longer Make Sense](#)
- [The Mechanics of Organizational Drift](#)
- [Reality Drift in Everyday Life](#)
- [Language Is What’s Left After Reality Gets Compressed](#)

Collected Semantic Fidelity Essays

[Semantic Fidelity Project - Substack](#)

The essay archive focused on how meaning changes as information is compressed, transformed, retrieved, summarized, and regenerated. It develops the language and mechanisms around semantic drift, fidelity loss, provenance, constraint, and representational failure.

Selected essays:

- [When Accuracy Isn't Enough: Toward Semantic Fidelity in AI Systems](#)
- [The Compression Paradox: Why Meaning Breaks Before Models Fail](#)
- [Constraint Collapse: When Feedback Stops Correcting Symbolic Systems](#)
- [Measuring Fidelity Decay: Tracking Meaning Collapse in Generative Systems](#)

Collected Cognitive Drift Essays

[Cognitive Drift Papers - Substack](#)

Selected writing on cognition, recursive thought, artificial intelligence, cognitive compression, externalized reasoning, and the changing relationship between human thought and digital systems.

Selected essays:

- [Recursive Compression: How Systems Build Stability Through Memory and Feedback](#)
- [Co-Cognition: How Predictive Minds Link to Digital Systems](#)
- [How Language Stabilized Human Thought](#)
- [Why Modern Cognition Rarely Resolves](#)

Structured Research Repositories

GitHub provides the structured repository layer for the project, preserving framework materials, research documents, definitions, papers, and archival records in a more durable and inspectable form. The repositories are organized across the three main bodies of work: Reality Drift, the Semantic Fidelity Project, and the Cognitive Drift Papers. Together, they provide a structured record of the project's formal development and supporting materials.

- [Reality Drift Library – Github](#)
- [Semantic Fidelity Project - Github](#)
- [Cognitive Drift Papers - Github](#)

Archival Records

These records document the development, provenance, correction, and canonical status of the Reality Drift framework.

- [Reality Drift Framework Provenance Record](#) — Documents the framework’s development, authorship, chronology, and provenance.
- [Reality Drift Archival Status, Corrections, and Supersession Record](#) — Records canonical status, later corrections, and which materials supersede earlier formulations.

Mirrors and Additional Platforms

Additional copies, mirrors, presentations, and secondary distribution points help preserve access to the project across platforms.

- OSF ([Reality Drift](#), [Cognitive Drift](#), and [Semantic Fidelity Project](#)) — Research mirrors and archival distribution across three dedicated project spaces.
- [Academia.edu](#) — Secondary academic distribution and discovery.
- Internet Archive ([Reality Drift](#), [Cognitive Drift](#), and [Semantic Fidelity Project](#)) — Long-term preservation of selected project materials across three dedicated archive accounts.

Early Framework Development

[The Age of Drift: Why Modern Life Feels Fake - and What Reality Drift Reveals About the Modern Mind](#) (ISBN 9798276826493)

The Age of Drift collects early notes, observations, and developing ideas from the formation of the Reality Drift framework. The book is preserved as a record of early framework development but is no longer a canonical source. Its central concepts were later revised, formalized, and incorporated into the canonical papers, glossary, framework documents, and research collections listed above.

[Frameworks in Action - Archive](#)

A preserved collection of short-form explanations originally published in [r/FrameworksInAction](#) during the development of the Reality Drift framework. The archive captures early public versions of ideas around Reality Drift, optimization, Semantic Fidelity, Cognitive Drift, AI, institutions, and related mechanisms before they were refined into the later canonical papers, definitions, and visual models.